GUIDED CHILDHOOD

The Road to 16

THE GROWN UPS GUIDE TO THE WHOLE JOURNEY



BALANCE · BEHAVIOUR · THE APPS · SCHOOL

Your reward for a Guided Childhood Passport stamped up to your child's age

STAMPED UP TO YOUR CHILD'S AGE

Your Passport is up to date



AWARDED TO THE

FAMILY

UP TO DATE ON

Every page up to your child's age has its talk, its doing and its check, all of them done at your own kitchen table. That took time, and it is yours now.

This guide is the map for the whole road, from the first tablet to the phone they carry out of the door at sixteen. Read the part your child is in now. Keep the rest where you will find it again: the stages ahead come round as they grow, and the ones behind are there for any brother or sister coming up.

WHAT IS INSIDE

PART ONE

Balance

Three kinds of time, and the one rule that never moves.

PART TWO

Behaviour

What to watch for at each stage, and what to say when you see it.

PART THREE

The apps

Each app's own minimum age, the setting to lock first, and what to watch for.

PART FOUR

School

The moments that bring the pressure, from the game the whole class plays to Year 11.

One thing to hold onto. The minimum age on each app is the company's own account rule. It is not a sign a child is ready. Readiness is your child, the settings you lock together, and the talks you have already had.

THE WHOLE ROAD ON ONE PAGE

Five stages, four to sixteen

The same five pages as your Passport. Each stage has a focus, a device that usually fits it, and one talk that matters most.



Pebble
4 TO 7

STAGE 1 · FOUNDATION

First relationships with technology, before habits form

THE DEVICE
A shared family device, with you in the room

THE TALK
The First Device Conversation



Bloop
8 TO 10

STAGE 2 · BUILDER

Building digital habits before the algorithm learns them

THE DEVICE
A shared device, moving toward a supervised one of their own

THE TALK
The Bedroom Rule



Orbit
11 TO 12

STAGE 3 · EXPLORER

The algorithm conversation, before social media

THE DEVICE
A first device of their own, ideally a phone for calls and texts before a smartphone

THE TALK
The Algorithm Conversation



Nova
13 TO 15

STAGE 4 · SHAPER

Identity and digital footprint, while the relationship still holds

THE DEVICE
A smartphone, with family guidelines you agreed together

THE TALK
When Things Go Wrong Online



Cosmo
16 AND UP

STAGE 5 · INDEPENDENT

Real digital independence, before they leave home

THE DEVICE
Their own smartphone. The talk is now about digital literacy

THE TALK
Building Independence

PART ONE

Balance: three kinds of time

A screen time fight is often really about who decides. Splitting the day into three kinds of time settles that before anyone is upset.

ONE

Their time

A small amount every day that is simply theirs. You set it, they do not earn it, and it is never taken away as a punishment. That keeps the screen from becoming the biggest prize in the house.

TWO

Earned time

Extra time comes from jobs and chores. One star is five minutes to start with, and you can change the rate. Family jobs like laying the table sit outside the deal, because helping at home is part of belonging.

THREE

Protected time

Sleep, meals and school hours. No amount of stars buys these. If they want a screen inside protected time, they ask you, and you decide it together.

Protect these first

Start with what screens can crowd out of a day: sleep, moving about, playing, and being bored long enough to think of something. Look after those, then decide the rest.

Where it is heading

You decide, then you decide together, then they decide for themselves. The aim all along is that by sixteen they do not need the system at all.

THE ONE RULE THAT NEVER MOVES

Devices sleep outside bedrooms. Set up a charging station in the kitchen or the hallway, start it before the first phone arrives, and it is simply where phones live rather than something taken away later.

YOUR PHONE TOO, STAGE BY STAGE



4 TO 7 When the timer ends their screen time, put your own phone away too. The rule is for the house.



8 TO 10 Charge your own phone in the kitchen overnight, next to theirs. One rule for everyone is the easiest rule to keep.



11 TO 12 Say it out loud when you stop scrolling: "I have been on that too long, I am putting it down."



13 TO 15 Give them the right to call you out when you are on your phone at the table. It is the same right you are asking for.



16 AND UP Be honest about your own phone: what it gives you, and what it costs you.

PART TWO

Behaviour: what to watch for

These are the signs the app names at each stage. One on its own may just be a bad week, and many of them can come from school, friends or sleep as much as from a screen. A sign that keeps coming back, or a few together, is worth a calm talk. None of them is a diagnosis.



Pebble

4 TO 7

- Tantrums or real distress when a device is taken away
- Choosing screens over play every time they have a choice
- No longer interested in activities they loved before devices



Bloop

8 TO 10

- Using devices secretly or hiding what they watch
- Starting to compare themselves to what they see online
- Mood changes around device removal that feel out of proportion



Orbit

11 TO 12

- Mood drops noticeably after phone use
- Worry about being left out of what is happening online
- Checking the phone after lights out
- Withdrawal from family conversations



Nova

13 TO 15

- Secretive phone use, or panic if you pick up the device
- Big mood swings tied to things that happen online
- Online relationships that feel more real than offline ones
- Dropping activities they used to enjoy



Cosmo

16 AND UP

- Measuring their worth through likes, followers or numbers
- Struggling to be present in real life situations
- Real distress when they are without their phone
- No offline friendships or activities that matter to them

WHEN YOU NOTICE ONE

Write down what you see for a week, before and after screens. Share it as something you noticed, not a conclusion.

Then ask: "I have noticed your mood sometimes changes after being on your phone. Have you noticed that?" Leave space for the silence. Do not fill it.

NOT THIS

"That app is rotting your brain." That shuts the conversation down before it starts.

If you are worried about your child's health or safety, talk to their GP or their school. If anyone is in danger now, call 999.

PART THREE

The apps, and when they turn up

Each app sets its own minimum age in its terms, and most say 13. Ofcom found 90% of 8 to 12 year olds say they use at least one service with a minimum age of 13, led by YouTube, which under 13s can use through a parent's supervised account. About a third of parents know the usual age is 13. Each card names the Passport page where the Guided Childhood app brings that app up, so you are ready before your child asks.

YouTube

BLOOP PAGE · 8 TO 10

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Younger children can use it when a parent turns it on: YouTube Kids, or a supervised account, which you can set up in Google Family Link.

LOCK FIRST

Set it up through Google Family Link and choose the content setting that fits their age, then set a daily time limit on the Shorts feed.

WATCH FOR

The Shorts feed, which scrolls on with no natural end, so set its limit first.

Roblox

BLOOP PAGE · 8 TO 10

5
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Accounts from age 5, with some features only a parent can turn on. Chat needs an age check first.

LOCK FIRST

Set a Parental PIN so settings cannot be changed, then a monthly spending limit.

WATCH FOR

Chat inside games, user made games with adult content, and free Robux scams.

WhatsApp

ORBIT PAGE · 11 TO 12

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

A standard account has no parental dashboard, so this one is managed with settings and conversation. WhatsApp is rolling out parent managed accounts for under 13s, which may not have reached the UK yet.

LOCK FIRST

Settings, Privacy, Groups, set to My contacts, so strangers cannot add them to a group.

WATCH FOR

Being added to big groups by unknown numbers, and disappearing messages.

Instagram

ORBIT PAGE · 11 TO 12

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Teen Accounts are private by default, with the strictest messaging settings, and under 16s need a parent's permission to make them less strict.

LOCK FIRST

Check the Teen Account defaults are still on: messages only from people they follow, and Sleep mode overnight.

WATCH FOR

A false birthday can stop the teen protections switching on, so check it is real.

One thing to hold onto. The minimum age on each app is the company's own account rule. It is not a sign a child is ready. Readiness is your child, the settings you lock together, and the talks you have already had.

🎵 TikTok

 ORBIT PAGE · 11 TO 12

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Direct messages are off for under 16s.

LOCK FIRST

Link Family Pairing from your own phone, then set daily screen time and the content filters.

WATCH FOR

How fast the For You feed narrows to one kind of video.

👻 Snapchat

 ORBIT PAGE · 11 TO 12

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Family Center shows who they are friends with and have messaged, but not what was said.

LOCK FIRST

Snap Map to Ghost Mode, so their location is hidden from everyone.

WATCH FOR

Quick Add suggesting them to friends of friends they have never met, and the passcode folder called My Eyes Only.

👍 Facebook and Messenger

 NOVA PAGE · 13 TO 15

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Meta Family Center covers Facebook and Messenger, for time spent and who they are in touch with.

LOCK FIRST

Who can message them set to friends, and location for Messenger turned off in the phone's own settings.

WATCH FOR

Message and friend requests from adults they do not know.

🎮 Discord

 NOVA PAGE · 13 TO 15

13
ITS OWN MINIMUM AGE

Family Center shows servers joined, friends added and who they message or call, but not what they write or say.

LOCK FIRST

Filter explicit images in all direct messages, and send non friend messages to a separate inbox.

WATCH FOR

Messages from strangers in public servers, and voice channels nobody watches.

THE LAW

Ages read from each app's own terms in November 2026. Terms and laws change. The UK government expects to restrict social media for under 16s from spring 2027, and for 16 and 17 year olds to have social media switched off between midnight and 6am by default, a setting they can change. Whatever the law does, the talks still matter, because a deadline is not a plan.

PART FOUR

The school moments

The pressure tends to arrive with the school year, not the birthday. Here are the moments to be ready for, and what to have in place before each one.



The game the whole class plays

YEARS 3 TO 5 · AGES 7 TO 10

Games like Roblox are a place to meet friends as well as a game, with chat and spending inside. Ask them to teach you their favourite and play together for ten minutes before you set any limit on it.

HAVE READY A Parental PIN and a spending limit.



The phone ask

YEAR 6 · AGES 10 TO 11

The walk to school alone and the move to secondary bring the ask, and Ofcom says the key age for owning a phone seems to be around that move. Write the phone plan in Year 5, while it is still a plan: what the phone is for, where it charges at night, and the promise that telling you about a problem will never cost them the phone.

Ofcom found phone ownership rises from 56% of 10 year olds to 83% of 11 year olds.

HAVE READY The phone plan, written together. A phone for calls and texts with no apps gives independence without the feed.



The group chats

YEAR 7 · AGES 11 TO 12

A new school means new class and club groups, and some of them keep going late into the night. Teach group chat skills before the first group: how to leave a chat that turns nasty, and that a screenshot of anything upsetting comes to you and costs them nothing. The one exception is a nude or sexual picture of anyone under 18: they never screenshot it or send it on, they just tell you.

WhatsApp's own minimum age in the UK is 13, so a child in Year 7 is almost always younger than that. Ofcom found 52% of 8 to 12 year olds say they use it, and around two thirds of 8 to 17 year olds had been added or invited to a group chat in the past four weeks.

HAVE READY Groups set to My contacts, and the phone charging outside the bedroom.



The thirteenth birthday

YEARS 8 AND 9 · AGES 12 TO 14

Most of the big apps set 13 as their minimum, so the birthday brings the ask for TikTok, Snapchat and Instagram. Meet it with a readiness check instead of a yes or a no: have you had the algorithm talk, will you set the settings up together, and do they know you are their first call?

HAVE READY The Orbit page done, and the settings on pages 6 and 7 locked side by side.



Photos and pressure

YEARS 9 AND 10 · AGES 13 TO 15

Being asked for a photo, or a photo being shared around, is a talk to have before it happens. If anyone threatens to share an image of them or demands money: do not pay, do not delete anything, help them stop replying and block the account, and report it to CEOP or to the police on 101, or 999 if they are in danger now. Tell them out loud that they are not to blame and not in trouble.

HAVE READY The first call promise from the Nova page, said again.



Exams and revision

YEAR 11 · AGES 15 TO 16

Revision with a buzzing phone is hard for anyone. Notifications off for the revision window, the phone in another room, and the exam weeks named as protected time in your family agreement.

HAVE READY Protected school hours and a homework window from the first phone.

Since September 2026, statutory guidance asks schools in England to keep phones out of use all school day, breaks and lunch included, with exceptions such as a medical need. Ask for your school's own policy, and make yours at home match it.

KEEP THIS PAGE

When something goes wrong online



SAY THIS

"If anything ever goes wrong online, and things do go wrong, I am the first call you make, not the last. I will not overreact. I will help."

Say it before anything happens, then say it again every so often.

1. **Stay calm**
   Thank them for telling you. Whatever it is, they came to you.
2. **Keep the phone with them**
   Telling you should never cost them their phone. A child who expects to lose it has one more reason to stay quiet.
3. **Keep the evidence**
   Screenshot the messages and the account name, keeping any nude or sexual image out of the shot. Never copy, save or send on a nude or sexual image of anyone under 18, even to report it, and do not delete it either. The one exception is Report Remove, below, which your child uses for an image of themselves.
4. **Block and report**
   In the app first. If it involves classmates, tell the school, whose Designated Safeguarding Lead is there for exactly this.
5. **Check in again**
   Decide the next step together, and come back to it in a few days.

WHERE TO GET HELP, IN THE UK

Someone is in danger now	**999**
Worried about sexual contact, grooming or someone asking for images	**Report it to CEOP at ceop.police.uk**
A nude image of your child is online	**Your child can report it to Report Remove, from Childline and the IWF, for under 18s, at childline.org.uk**
Your child wants to talk to someone who is not you	**Childline, free and confidential, on 0800 1111**
You want advice as a parent	**The NSPCC helpline on 0808 800 5000**
You are worried about their health	**Their GP, or NHS 111 (in Northern Ireland, your GP's out of hours service)**

THE END OF THE ROAD

Sixteen: the handover



At sixteen the job changes. You set fewer of the rules and become more the person they talk things through with.

COSMO'S TALK

"You are at the age where you get to decide what kind of digital life you build. What does your online presence say about who you are? Not to me. To the world."

A digital audit, as equals

Go through their online presence together as equals rather than parent and child. What does it say? What would they change?

One calm talk before they go

Sextortion, deepfakes and AI made images are real at this age. Have one specific, calm talk about what they would do if anything went wrong, and who they would call.

Three questions to ask each other

What does your phone give you?

What does it cost you?

What would you change about it?



For the next one coming up

The Guided Childhood app runs the same Passport for you: each stage with its lessons, every script and a short stage check, and the stamps land on their own. guidedchildhood.com

WHERE IT COMES FROM

Sources

Every age and figure in this guide, and where it was read. The advice itself is the Guided Childhood app's own, stage by stage.

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15. **Sextortion.** National Crime Agency, urgent warning about sextortion, 29 April 2024, nationalcrimeagency.gov.uk. Read 5 November 2026.
16. **Nude images of under 18s.** UK Council for Internet Safety, Sharing nudes and semi nudes: how to respond to an incident, updated March 2024 (gov.uk). Read 5 November 2026.
17. **The NSPCC helpline for adults.** gov.uk/report-child-abuse. Read 5 November 2026.
18. **The advice, stage by stage.** The Guided Childhood app: each stage's focus, device, talks, signs to watch and your phone, the settings guide for each app, and the school moments.

This guide is general information for families, not medical, legal or safeguarding advice about your child. If you are worried, talk to your child's school, your GP, or one of the services on the help page.